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Author(s): Allan Lincoln Langley

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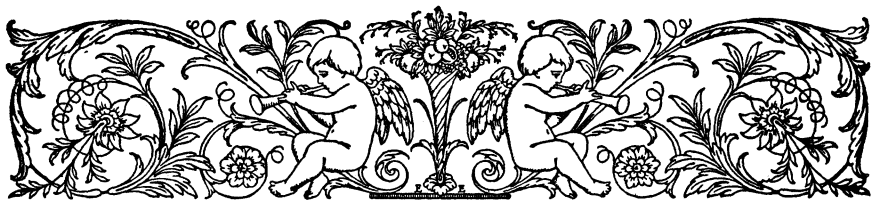
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## JUSTICE FOR GUSTAV MAHLER

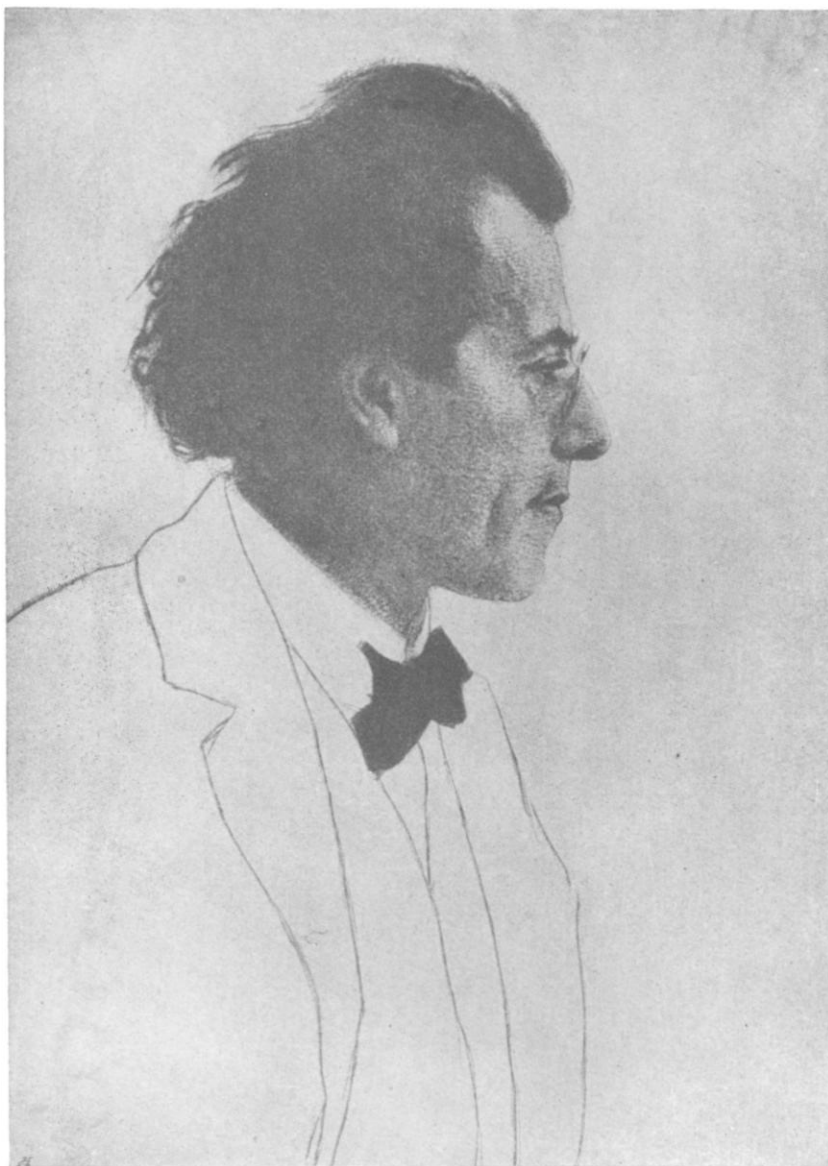
By ALLAN LINCOLN LANGLEY

### I

**T**O play a symphony by Gustav Mahler has become about the most dangerous and thankless thing a New York conductor can do, if he has to reckon with the effect of his temerity on professional critical opinion. My proofs? Let me refer at random to three columns that appeared, some time ago, in the newspaper of which until recently Mr. Deems Taylor was the musical critic. These were headed, respectively, "The Mountain in Labor," "In Darkest Mahler," and "The Friends of Mahler." The first referred to the 3rd Mahler symphony, the second to the 7th, and the third to "Das Lied von der Erde." The following excerpts are informative:

"The third symphony . . . a work of almost unbelievable prolixity, dulness and sterility . . . contains only a few scattered passages worth taking seriously." "We fail to see why we should devote much precious space to saying that we found the work [the seventh symphony] to be emphatically the most stupid piece of music that we ever heard. . . . We could find no single musical idea that possessed a vestige of significance and vitality . . . themes . . . inconceivably banal and vulgar, development long-winded and inept, scoring scrappy, muddy and ineffective . . ." "Das Lied von der Erde" . . . is the work of a composer who was pitifully destitute of the elements of greatness."

These are but small bits from one critic, but I could go on for pages quoting reports, lying at my elbow, of five or six others, equally eminent in their profession. Mr. Aldrich, for instance, states that "There are two composers New York will not listen to—Mahler and Berlioz," and "the seventh symphony . . . is the



**Gustav Mahler**  
(After the portrait etching by Orlik, 1902)

final *reductio ad absurdum* of Mahler's pretensions to be a composer"; and Mr. Henderson believes that "the thematic material of the [seventh] symphony is mean beyond description."

Most assuredly critics are entitled to their annihilating opinions, but my complaint is that so much of their comment on Mahler's works is abusive rather than critical in tone. Furthermore, if Mr. Lawrence Gilman, as late as February 1924, says that "The Mahler question is as unsettled as ever," I protest that there existed no such mooted "Mahler question" in America until created by the critics themselves. As a member of both orchestras and audiences at many Mahler performances, I have never noticed any direct hostility among the hearers. Bewilderment there was (as also after the first performance of the "Eroica"); doubt, certainly; indifference, as there must always be. But there was also awe, respect and a decided amount of mere suspended judgment. The critics, however, have never given this suspended judgment a chance. Had they not smothered it, Mahler could take his place in the repertoire without any "question" whatever.

This process was, in fact, in a fair way to succeed up to 1921 when Mengelberg's too sanguine ardor unloosed the critical flood-gates. Previous to that no special opposition had been noticeable. The performance by the Philadelphia Orchestra under Stokowski of the Eighth Symphony (in 1916, I think) has been termed by Arthur Judson, who managed it, as the only symphonic venture of its kind in his recollection that made money. Six or seven performances were given in Philadelphia and New York; two or three sold-out houses for extra repetitions had to be cancelled on account of the sheer exhaustion of the chorus and orchestra. Dr. Muck's performance in 1918 of the Second (also choral) symphony is yet fresh in the memory of Boston enthusiasts, and Mengelberg's presentations of the Third and Seventh were quite enthusiastically received despite the assertion that only the performance, and not the music, justified the applause. Mengelberg in 1921 also brought out the First and Fourth symphonies to adequate receptions; it was only then that the anti-Mahler campaign gathered its forces and speedily acquired its present characteristics.

But, says the imperturbable connoisseur, isn't this just another magnifying of the molehill? Does not all music stand or fall, eventually, by its real merits, regardless of criticism? Against such languid Pollyanna sentiments it becomes necessary to demolish the superstition that Mahler, or any other serious composer for that matter, can make his way unaided.

Consider that Mahler has been dead only fourteen years. He composed serious music in the largest form—the symphony. His music depends on the largest orchestras for performance; it cannot be played effectively in reduced arrangements. Altogether, including “*Das Lied von der Erde*” there are nine symphonies and an unfinished tenth. The enormous resources, including substantial choruses, demanded in at least three of them, limit the number ordinarily easy to perform to five. They are without exception longer than most symphonies, and conceived in so deliberately introspective a style that at least two or three hearings are necessary before even a well-disposed musician can grasp them. As matters stand at present, the average frequency of Mahler performances is something less than one in two years, and this estimate leaves out some orchestras which do not play him at all. Since his music is of the type that must first seem erudite and complex before it can appear emotional, it depends upon time and repetition for general appreciation.

Beethoven, it is admitted, is great. So is Brahms. So also Wagner and Debussy. Yet how many of these secured the undisputed standing they enjoy to-day when their works were first being presented? Mr. Ernest Newman notwithstanding, it is fairly established that all were at first more or less opposed, criticized, even vilified by influential contemporary opinion. Moreover, the acceptance of all their works is by no means admitted to-day. Is Beethoven’s triple concerto considered a masterpiece? Or his trios for strings alone? How much emotional pleasure does the average concert-goer derive from some of the last quartets, say the op. 135, or the fugue, both of which may be considered “musicians’ music” beyond much dispute? What about Debussy’s “*Jeux*,” or his second-rate Prix de Rome composition, “*La Demoiselle Éluë*”? And what is the general opinion of Brahms’ earlier chamber-music, and of “*Rienzi*”? These are mere suggestions, not especially comprehensive or conclusive, but when one considers the elasticity of judgment granted the generally accepted masters, it becomes ridiculous to deny the same privileges to the consideration of Mahler.

Enough has been said to justify the assertion that Mahler is a man who must be reckoned with. His symphonies are tremendous. They demand a patient and studious approach. It is absurd to condemn them on account of their length. Their form is often different from the traditional symphony of three or four movements; the third, for example, has six. The music itself makes little effort to ingratiate, although it often does so uncon-

sciously. While abounding in graceful and poignant episodes, it seldom evinces any responsibility to sustain them. The most significant feature of these symphonies, in fact, is the introspective character that utterly disclaims any intention of architectural simplicity. In this particular lies the crux of the whole Mahler matter, and it is astounding that so few seem to recognize that Mahler did not try to establish competition with other composers, but merely invited the hearer to share his own musical adventures.

Such an invitation should be enough for anyone who pretends to be a musician. It should also suffice the lay-listener, because the specifics of composer-craft are beyond him anyway. And since the mere trading of contentious opinions is of doubtful use in trying to show the worth of a composer, it is essential to bring simple goodwill to the task of stating the qualifications of the perfect Mahlerite and the attitude by which Mahler can be enjoyed.

I purposely forbear to make use of existing critical and biographical documents. It is not unlikely that the enthusiastic study of Mahler by Paul Stefan is influenced by the peculiarly idolatrous taint of all priesthood; a quality that should be everlastingly opposed and which I wish could be altogether eliminated from musical history. Stefan is the most authoritative writer on Mahler, but his book is not unguilty of the "Pathetic Fallacy." Romain Rolland, most catholic of French critics, even in opposition to Mahler contrives to maintain comparative fairness; but his article in "Musicians of To-day" proves that he lacked the patience to make him sympathetic. My business, as I see it, is to suggest rather than to shout; to prepare, if possible, rather than to dogmatize.

Mahler was first a man of simple faith and ingenuousness. The fact that he chose to make use of humanitarian psychology in the programs of his symphonies establishes him at once as one of the composers to whom music meant transcribed emotion quite as much as pure sound. Mengelberg's placing of Mahler beside Bach and Beethoven in a new triumvirate of Titans is therefore conceivably consistent. Aside from the mere quality of music, there is a peculiar similarity in the æsthetic pronouncements of these three. Bach's life was humility itself, filled with polite dedications and religious fervor. Beethoven, though far more robust and capable of fury, followed with a continuation of the Bach uplift-politic; what other explanation accounts for the constant effort to ennoble, to crystallize elemental feelings, that literally pours from his greatest music? And likewise did Mahler



propose to paint human life in its simplest relations and qualities. It is, of course, permissible to shrug the shoulders and lament the lack of fine distinctions of sophistication in these men while insisting, as is often done, that in spite of themselves their music is more authentic speech than their precepts. But that widespread practice only begs the question after all; the composer always has the right to record the sources of his inspiration.

So, when we come to examine Mahler the man, we are, if we wish it, close on the track of understanding, and subsequently appreciating, his music. No composer sits down deliberately to write a two-and-a-half-hour symphony for the fun of it, or for popularity and frequent performances. He has a more serene purpose: courage is his most outstanding quality. Not to make a short, titillating "sure-fire" piece, as nearly all contemporary composers are doing, by the way; but to follow his idea faithfully from one end to the other is his real business, and if he is sincere he sticks to it. He is not responsible to anyone but himself, and he is false to that important being if he flinch, or plot the facile success. In fulfilling this particular ideal Mahler is, with the possible exception of Bruckner, the most sublimely courageous and unspoiled personality in the history of music.

So much for his purpose; now for the specifics of his craft. Mahler is accused of sterility, disjointedness, prolixity; of fragmentary themes, banality, plagiarism, padding, mere noise: a large order, in all conscience. It is necessary to combat every word in this list separately, although one suspects that the anti-Mahlerite suffers principally from unwillingness and inability to surrender to the personality of the composer. If prejudice be left behind and one listen to absorb rather than to criticize, the sterility becomes a picture of desperate human futility, the disjointedness a transcription of painful human struggle, the prolixity an attest of the long and wearisome road to some spiritual orientation. When these convictions are gradually borne in on one, Mahler is seen as a man who has done something entirely new with musical mediums—something that perhaps only Bruckner approached before him—the creating of a musical fabric by means of ungilded realistic psychology, with as much emphasis on the unprepossessing as on the charming. This is more faithful depicting of life than a simple panorama where everything may be labeled and is as easy to understand as a variety-show.

The remainder of the catalogue of *contras* is of technical import only; yet they are inextricably related to the creative psychology of the whole, and the Mahlerite, searching for a

solution, must realize this. The "fragmentary themes" are like iterated suggestions of moods, which in life are by no means always complete and clearly charted. The "banality" is often purposeful—musical transference of oft-felt stupidities and cheapenings. The plagiarism indictment is a joke, and indeed a poor one: such few chance resemblances as occur in Mahler are certainly as innocuous as many others in better-known symphonists. Arthur Sullivan's famous *riposte* is apposite here: "My dear sir, you must remember that I and Mr. X—— had but seven notes to work with!" In substance or outline Mahler has never plagiarized to the slightest degree. "Padding?" Well, there is padding in Beethoven, although it is *lèse majesté* to say so. "Mere noise?" Mahler was capable, as is well known, of terrific passion and fervor, and it is not strange that once in a while he dwells a little longer on some stupendous effect than the dull and timid temperament can stand. "Inability to sustain a mood"—but I have already suggested that his "moods" relate conjointly to his huge introspective emotional schemes.

There remains the matter of orchestration. Even that is belittled in New York, and yet Mahler's instrumentation is altogether as distinctive as that of any major symphonist of the last fifty years. *Pax* to the classicists, we have four prominent figures in orchestral progress: Wagner, Mahler, Strauss and Debussy. I do not include Stravinsky because his music, though legitimate, is not essentially for the concert-hall. Strauss and Debussy are practically self-developed in their best work. Wagner absorbed Liszt, and Mahler to some extent Bruckner; but in either case the successor moulded himself a *genre* that cannot be imitated short of actual copying. The work of d'Indy, Rubin Goldmark and a host of lesser composers proves the Wagner contention beyond dispute; the imitation of Mahler would be equally apparent. His uses of certain combinations are unique. His massed clarinet- and oboe-chords; his shrieks of close-packed reeds, with appoggiaturas to every note of the chord; his development of the possibilities of the E-flat clarinet—only Strauss in "Eulenspiegel" and "Heldenleben" has equalled it; his introduction of tortuous string *glissandi* before any other composer was doing it, and with manner and effect totally different from the more familiar exponents of that trick, Debussy and Ravel; his novel effects of pure devastating ugliness; his unforgettable ingenuity in what might be termed *leit*-rhythms; his unerring choice of the definitive tone-quality to express a certain needed emotion—let any other composer so much as dare to employ Mahler's technique literally,



and even Mr. Deems Taylor would be reduced to crying "Thief!"

The Mahlerite hears these things, measures them, and kindles. He knows his patience may be tried, but the rich and constantly varying pageant atones for its length. He accepts that length because it constitutes the height and breadth of the man himself. He finds the short ephemeral melodic phrases more piquant for their sheer unreliability, their chance blossoming amid the realistic seriousness; he appreciates their exquisite individuality all the better because they are not always logically and inevitably developed. He likes the casual wandering, because it spells life to him. Mahler can do as much with three isolated measures of snatch-melody as Strauss with three pages of polyphony. What is that phrase that both haunts and taunts you just because it is not "finished," because you can't quite see it? Well, it is no less than the flower your friend's automobile did not stop for you to pick, or the chance girl who stepped into the subway train you just missed. Must life be all fulfilment?

But aside from such particular fancies, delightful as he makes them, Mahler does not always elect to play with nebulous emotions. The shorter **movements** are often the epitome of grace and line. To cite a few: The grotesque dead-march in the first symphony; the second and third movements of the second, one an exquisite *Ländler*-like piece and the other a boisterous Viennese scherzo; the **flower**-movement of the third symphony, and its tense exordium that serves as a finale; the *Totentanz* of the fourth, the string-serenade of the fifth, the *Nachtmusik* of the seventh and the intervening *Schattenhaft*. For delicacy and refinement some of these movements are unsurpassed in all musical literature. In fact, the education that must accompany growing attention to Mahler can be confined almost entirely to the long movements which at first seem not to speak for themselves.

Finally, taken as a whole, the Mahler symphonies are majestic in their scope and magnificence. There is a herculean achievement there which never goes unnoticed even by an audience made half hostile in advance. When the third symphony, a titanic two-and-a-half-hour production, was ended, blank silence was the first reaction. Frankly, the audience could not analyse its emotion—and small blame to it. The sheer magnitude stunned. But a few seconds later came the realization that whether it had understood or not, it had heard a work nearly unparalleled in force of utterance. The applause burst forth in storms (there had fortunately been no *advance* criticisms!) and the vindication of the

insistent Mengelberg was accomplished as well as that of Mahler's frenetic devotion. If that tremendous symphony had left the audience tongue-tied and paralysed it would have had its justification. With the others, most of which are shorter than the mammoth third, less handicap in the matter of endurance is to be encountered. With repeated hearings they will unfold the more easily, and it need not be long before the definite episodes reshape themselves like old friends and the more distended portions throw off a readier emotional glamour. For variety the listener need not fear. That is why Mahler's symphonies are so fascinating. You never know what to expect.

## II

The foregoing portion of this article, despite its generous allowance of affirmations, has been mostly concerned with an endeavor to refute the prejudice with which Mahler's works have had to contend in America. There remains the necessity of completing the explanation of Mahler's sources and the plain duty of listing those conductors who have assumed the more or less thankless task of presenting his works. To dispose first of the latter task, it may be recorded that in addition to the greatest Mahler interpreter, Mengelberg, symphonies of Mahler have been performed by Muck, Monteux, Stokowski, Stock, Gabrilowitsch, Bodanzky and Bruno Walter, all within the last decade. If there be others, I have not had recourse to the proof and so am unable to include them. Muck, to my knowledge, gave the second and fifth; Monteux and Walter the first (both during the season of 1923-1924); Gabrilowitsch the first; Stokowski the eighth as previously recorded; while Stock of the Chicago orchestra has the most impressive list available, including the following performances, in pairs: three of the fourth, three of the seventh (including its first performance in America), one of the first, one of the fifth, three special performances of the eighth (a special music-festival), and also Mahler's "*Lieder eines Fahrenden Gesellen*" (Songs of a Travelling Journeyman); all since 1914. Bodanzky repeatedly performed "*Das Lied von der Erde*" and the fourth symphony. Mengelberg has given the first four and the seventh, and we may hope for the others in due time.

It is worthy of comment that the performances of Mahler outside of New York are no such breeders of controversy. While it would be of course idle to maintain that the audiences of Detroit, Philadelphia, Boston and Chicago are much more aware of Mahler's

worth than those of Manhattan, it is obvious that, as long as the critics of these other communities discuss the symphonies without rancor and accept them, whether approved or not, as entitled at least to the occasional presentations they receive, their hearers have a much better chance of learning to listen to and appreciate them than the New Yorkers to whom on every possible occasion Mahler has been portrayed as a musical hypochondriac, delinquent and bore. Boston and Chicago at least take their Mahler without questioning; and it is undoubtedly an advantage, as also in Philadelphia, for the critics to honor their conductors enough to keep personal contentions largely absent from their articles. When Muck and Monteux and Stock have given Mahler symphonies, their reputations and beliefs have not been impugned to any noticeable extent, whereas in New York Mengelberg has been treated rather roughly because he has insistently and doggedly adhered to his opinion that Mahler is one of the greatest. As for Pierre Monteux and Bruno Walter, they were raked over the coals because they were intrepid enough each to give the first symphony a hearing in the same season. Walter was censured for not playing a different symphony of Mahler's; and Monteux for daring as the leader of an outside organization to insult omniscient New York (just as it was becoming well-trained in anti-Mahlerism) by playing Mahler at all. I, on the contrary, felt like extending both Messrs. Monteux and Walter a token of gratitude for allowing me to hear twice in a few weeks a work I had never been able before to listen to, and had played in only once.

To complete the consideration of Mahler's sources involves the bestowing of due credit on the editor of this magazine. Having been unable for more or less obvious reasons to publish even in shorter form this article in other supposedly suitable places, I entered into editorial correspondence with Mr. Sonneck, who saw the fairness of my proposition to present the other side of the "Mahler-question" and suggested that I do so more comprehensively than in the article as originally submitted to him. During the correspondence Mr. Sonneck also thought fit to acquaint me with some of his own convictions, which I reproduce here almost verbatim, since they are forcefully and convincingly stated:

Among the aspects of Mahler's art is one which, in my humble opinion, is essential for its understanding: that is, the spirit of the German folk-song. Mahler was saturated with the romanticism of "Des Knaben Wunderhorn" and practically all of his music echoes that influence in one way or another. If an auditor has no knowledge or

spiritual connection with that romanticism he will never be able really to appreciate Mahler entirely. In our country that particular German romanticism is an unknown sphere, except among a comparatively few individuals. Therefore the key to [one] secret of Mahler's art is missing; or rather, without that key it becomes much more difficult to understand what is an essential part of Mahler's ideals and their expression. That is really the principal reason why in Central Europe and Holland Mahler's music sounds at home and strikes such a sympathetic note in the listeners. Inversely, it is why it is so difficult to transplant and export Mahler to any other country.

The folk-music spirit accounts for much in Mahler's music that the opposition considers banal, for the simple reason that much of the folk-music of all nations has frequently an element of banality about it. Because certain outstanding folk-melodies are perfect gems of beauty, too many people have the opinion that every folk-song is beautiful. That is not at all true. Many a folk-song is genuine, but at the same time it is esthetically ordinary and reflects the banality of the "folk" crowd or individual in that crowd. Embracing humanity as he saw it, Mahler was in that respect a realistic idealist. He did not embellish the folk-spirit, but reflected it in his music as it actually is, and in my opinion it is a virtue and not a defect in Mahler that at times he did not shrink from a refined sort of banality when his ideas demanded it. Unless one keeps the German folk-song in mind which he so loved and tried to reflect faithfully, though racially not a Nordic, one loses, for instance, the point in one of his symphonies [the third] where he pictures the psychology of the surging crowd and injects suddenly the tune of "Ich hatt' einen Kameraden." When that symphony was performed in New York, hardly any of the critics seemed to know what that fairly banal tune was. The critics merely heard a banal tune and took it for granted that it was a tune of Mahler's own, injected by him without rhyme or reason.

Finally, Mahler cannot be understood fully unless one sees in him an antipode of Richard Strauss. Both are programme-composers, but Strauss in the main is a naturalistic program-composer, whereas Mahler is a psychological program-composer. In Richard Strauss the pictorial element of the program dominates that of the mood, while in Mahler the pictorial element is subservient to a portrayal of psychic states.

The main point as to Mahler's affiliation with the folk-music spirit is well taken and is undoubtedly important. Disclaiming any desire to use these evident facts as a basis for argument, I must, however, state that while subscribing fully to them I nevertheless feel it even more important to point out that the concert-going public should learn the necessity of looking further than explanatory notes and historical data and create for themselves a conquest of that laziness of mind which relies upon specific information for its comfort and stimulation. The enjoyment of music is and must remain largely an individual matter, even among musicians, and true satisfaction can seldom result unless the music

has the power to evoke either visions or moods. What I have already pointed out is that the critics have damned Mahler so heartily that the layman could scarcely be expected to dare believe there was anything worth his consideration; and what I have tried to show is that preserving receptive ingenuousness will enable the same layman to keep his ears and mind open until the evocative power of Mahler's music gradually comes home to him. In discussing the German folk-music element in Mahler I would not go so far as to say, with Mr. Sonneck, that without a spiritual kinship with it one could not appreciate Mahler;<sup>1</sup> but at the same time I would go farther and say that the spirit of *universal* folk-music should appear and appeal to anyone with decently developed æsthetics and should set up thereby a means of mutual communication that should clarify both Mahler's purpose and the auditor's emotions.

Similarly, the question of Mahler's antipodal difference from Richard Strauss, though absolutely true, seems to me incidental rather than imperative. To realize the psychic programs of Mahler is not, I think, necessarily dependent upon recognizing the naturalistic programs of Strauss.<sup>2</sup> The latter are obvious; but not less so than the former. The quintessence of the matter is that throughout the gamut of human responses to art the pictorial has always had the advantage over the psychic, upon the same principle that sends ten persons to the movies where one prefers a book. When it is realized that the Straussian pageants have had in recent years from the standpoint of frequency of performance at least treble that 10-to-1 advantage over the Mahlerian introspections, I find it necessary only to reaffirm my original conviction, that given a proportionate number of presentations, Mahler would hold his own in any repertoire.

This article, it happens, was practically completed before the final Philharmonic program of 1924-1925, when Mengelberg gave his excellent and definitive performance of Mahler's second symphony. I therefore take the liberty of inserting a reference to an unheard-of phenomenon which then occurred. Mr. Pitts Sanborn inserted, or caused to be inserted, in the columns of the New York Telegram-Mail a short paragraph to the effect that after the first performance of such a work it was obvious that no critic could do it justice, and bade his readers wait until after the

<sup>1</sup>I did not say that; I said "to appreciate Mahler *entirely*."—O. G. S.

<sup>2</sup>I did not mean that; I meant that Mahler cannot be understood as a program-composer, if one listens to his music from the same angle as to that of Richard Strauss.—O. G. S.

repetition of the concert. Following this repetition there appeared in the Telegram-Mail of Monday, April 6, the first temperate criticism of Mahler it has been my pleasure to see in a New York newspaper during the last five years. In it Pitts Sanborn spoke admiringly of the salient beauties of the symphony, and very reservedly of parts he did not like or understand. He terminated his article, moreover, with the observation that, no matter whether the entire symphony had seemed admirable or not (which he wisely forbore to establish categorically), at least the audience had heard under Mengelberg a performance of unexampled fidelity and competence, and added that he for one was musically the richer for having been present on so momentous an occasion! That was criticism! As far as my memory serves me, it was the only critical article or concert-report about Mahler that ever contained evidence of a New York critic's realization of the necessity of a second guess. I have no hesitation in saying that Mr. Sanborn's unusual venture into the contemplative constituted a milestone along the path of Mahler-critiques, and if he will follow it up by performing at least as temperately when the much-reviled Bruckner begins to come into his own, he will have made his position unique and can retire with a clear conscience.

And now, having held forth belligerently as befitted the necessity of the problem, I wish before concluding to dismiss comparisons and controversies and to substitute what of belief and serenity my professional life as a musician has allowed me to retain. I have no desire longer to appear remote, as another critic merely. I am neither pretending omniscience nor professing priesthood. As for my fitness to be a Mahler advocate, it has no other origin than a slow course of personal acquaintance with Mahler's work as a participating musician who happens to be literate—fortunately or unfortunately the reader must decide for himself. I have played so far in five of these symphonies and have besides heard a sixth (as well as listening to two performances of the first). I, too, began by being doubtful of certain apparent banalities; I was not beyond the indiscretion of separating phrases, and carping at this or that. But (perhaps because I am a musician) my incipient indifference or enmity was ever and again arrested by some novel orchestral effect, startling rhythm, hauntingly graceful melody or significant figure; and I bade myself wait and consider. By the time the necessary five or six rehearsals were over, I found myself sucked into the current and inoculated with its contagious power. The concerts were usually the first uninterrupted performance—we seldom in the Philharmonic had time



for a general rehearsal of Mahler—and in no case did I experience disappointment or misgivings after they were over. The line of the whole remained intact, as one might look back at a mountain or an experience. A man had said something and I had heard; sincerity was in every utterance, and an enormous purpose pervaded all. It was humanity revealed, with no lies, no extenuations, no hypocrisy, no omissions. Beauty shone out fully as often as it does in human affairs; banality was there to torture, and disappointment to corrode. It was all in the music—one felt in Mahler a kinship to the oracular confessor, Walt Whitman: “I am the man—I suffered, I was there.” What more, I submit, than the power to reveal one’s self as a student, portrayer, and liver of life is needed to stamp the owner of that power with the seal of authentic artist?

And because I, too, had known the struggles, intimate terrors and exigencies of the composer and had literally bedded, night after night, with the merciless passion of affirmation, so hideously difficult to subdue and so painfully broken to worthy use, it became easy for me to understand the relentless fervors which, we have ample evidence, drove Mahler all his life, and found the particular sort of expression the symphonies present. That, however, is unimportant except insofar as it provides a bridge to my concluding plea to the music lover: Life is not by any means the joke or the pastime that we constantly try to make it. In it we try to minimize misfortune, to flee dulness, to forget grief, to deny defeat. Being but mortal, however, we seldom if ever succeed totally in annulling the effects of any of these, and if we remove ourselves by various gallant or cowardly stratagems from their influence, we none the less tend to become superficial despite the comparative safety of our doubtfully-bought deliverance. It was undoubtedly Mahler’s appreciation of the complexity of human affairs that enabled him to go so deliberately and courageously about the business of reproducing his understanding by his particular musical medium. My parting adjuration, therefore, is for audiences to consider the spirit of these remarks when next they listen to a Mahler symphony. To condemn wholly an artist before one understands his sources and purpose is to write oneself down an undeserver of the benefits that art confers.